

procedural problems involved with buying online. We talk about the main ones below and innovations that have been designed to overcome these problems, which are unique to India.

Internet Adoption

When e-commerce was introduced in India, the customer base in India was low due to the lack of Internet access for customers that did not live in the major metros of India. Moreover, even in the metros Internet speeds were slow and broadband was rela-



tively unheard of. This made creating a positive user experience for the customer a challenge for businesses who were forced to keep their sites simple, with few images. Therefore, the earlier versions of e-stores did not have the big images and elaborate product descriptions that we now take for granted.

Businesses also had to battle with the customers' innate need to touch and feel the product prior to purchasing it. In the early days of e-commerce customers had to rely solely on the product description listed on the site and the basic product images that accompanied this description. This required a significant trade off in terms of the shopping experience from the customer, which meant that online shopping was perceived as being risky.

India, a vast country

Due to the vast area that India is spread over and the unreliability of the postal system, e-commerce businesses had to invest significant amounts of money in planning the logistics and ensure that they were able to secure products from suppliers promptly and more importantly that customers received their products within the promised time-frame.

For the customer that had to already deal with the disadvantage of being unable to experience the product prior to purchase, thanks to the ambiguity of the Indian postal system there was also the risk that the product may not reach your doorstep. Moreover, if it didn't most e-commerce sites did